OTT

FOR A NEW GENERATION

INDIAN OTT PLATFORMS ARE WAKING UP TO THE MANY POSSIBILITIES OF CONTENT GEARED TOWARD YOUNG ADULTS





Netflix's slate includes season two of **MISMATCHED**, a college-set romance that has made stars out of its lead pair, Prajakta Koli and Rohit Saraf

Kuchh young adult mein bata dijiye (Pitch us something in the young adult genre)." Creator Abhishek Yadav has heard this request enough times to realise that he is now the very thing he avoids writing—a stereotype. With three hit shows to his credit—*Kota Factory* (2019-2021, TVF Play/ Netflix), *Hostel Daze* (2019-, Amazon Prime Video) and *Campus Diaries* (2022-, MX Player)—Yadav, the industry feels, knows the pulse of India's youth. An IIT Bombay graduate, Yadav joined The Viral Fever (TVF) and began developing shows that "cater to young adults who are interested in seeing themselves on screen". Interestingly, however, it was not just students who were drawn to these series. "I've realised that even three or four years after graduating, you are still stuck in that world," says Yadav. "Income tax still has not hit you. You thrive on nostalgia of the first crush, the first fight."

As per the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India, 46.9 per cent of India's population is now under the age of 25, but, surprisingly, we have very few shows that are for and about the young. This is in stark contrast to the US, where shows like *Euphoria* (2019-, Disney+ Hotstar), *Riverdale* (2017-, Netflix) and *Stranger Things* (2016-, Netflix) dominate the pop culture landscape. Our burgeoning OTT industry, though, has finally started recognising young adults as a demographic to be courted. Even though TVF has made young adult entertainment its forte with more shows—these include *Flames* (2018-2019, MX Player), *College Romance* (2018-, SonyLIV) and *ImMATURE* (2019-, MX Player)—the onus to develop content for the 18-24 age bracket now no longer rests on them alone.

Netflix, for one, is returning with season two of *Mismatched* (2020-), a college-set romance which has made stars out of its lead pair, Prajakta Koli and Rohit Saraf. The streaming giant also recently announced *The Archies*, a Zoya Akhtar-directed live action musical feature based on the iconic comic. Then there's *Eternally Confused and Eager for Love*, a series about a 24-year-old navigating adulthood and the daunting world of romance. On March 4, Lionsgate Play released its second original, *Jugaadistan*, a college drama with politics, friendship and romance as key themes.

For Mrinalini Khanna, vice president, originals, Lionsgate India, *Jugaadistan* captures "the gamut of not just emotions but also responsibilities the young generation faces, and the ambition and aspiration they have". With an ensemble cast that includes Ahsaas Channa—an actress whose popularity is built on young adult shows such as *Girls Hostel* (2018-, SonyLIV), *Hostel Daze* and *Kota Factory*—*Jugaadistan* looks to go beyond the